main gate of the ministry of defence in South Block. We were also accompanied by many senior officers from the Army HQ.

After the customary high tea, we bade our farewell to all those present, among whom were some of my principal staff officers, other senior colleagues, civilian staff from my secretariat and members of my team. I was then escorted to a flower-bedecked open jeep that was drawn by officers, junior commissioned officers and soldiers – a ceremonial send-off with the accompanying 'Jais' (victory or glory). This was a very moving moment for me since it represented my 'Farewell to Arms', and was a fitting finale for three generations of my family who had served the army. Adorning the ceremonial dress of a general of the Indian Army, my chest swelled more than usual with pride and my eyes were moist, as I realized that it was the last time I would be doing so! It had been the magnetic aura and attraction of the army uniform some forty-seven years earlier that had drawn me, a stripling of some fifteen years of age, to the portals of the National Defence Academy. What an epic journey it had been; carrying me from a 'one pipper' to the rank of a four-star general. Our cavalcade then drove past 4 Rajaji Marg, that had us glancing fondly at the 'White Gates', our recent home, and on to 20 Mandir Marg in the Delhi Cantonment, which was to be our temporary residence for the next year or so.

We dressed casually for the evening's 'dinner for two'. Suddenly, we had company. My team of the chief's secretariat, led by 'Bunny' Chetinder Singh and Venkat Gouder, descended upon us. They proceeded to invite us to an exclusive dinner that they had organized at the infantry officers' mess. They had quietly invited our entire family, including our parents and children. It was touching beyond compare to find my entire former personal staff and their wives present in the mess to welcome us, together with the bags and pipes band so beloved of the true infantryman. There was a carnival air in the mess and a joyful time was had by all with merrymaking, music, singing and dancing. The party seemed unending and carried on till the wee hours of the morning. It could be labelled as the *Balle Balle* evening, what with all of us singing and dancing, *Mauja hi*